

Suprasegmentals: Intonation

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What is intonation?

- Pitch variation.
- Doesn't affect individual word-meaning, unlike Chinese.
- But may change the meaning of the entire utterance.



Intonation: An Italian example

Fa freddo:

- Falling intonation: *It is cold*
- Rising intonation: *Is it cold?*

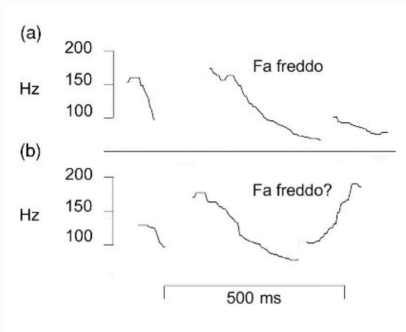


Figure 1: Fundamental frequency for Italian "Fa freddo" and "Fa freddo?".



- Chunks of words of a sentence.
- Unique intonation property.
- IPs make a sentence manageable to say.



Same sentence, different IP

Speaker 1

- It was a windy day || and the child went out || to fly a kite || but she was out of luck that afternoon || as it started to rain cats and dogs || not too late after she was beginning to have fun.

Speaker 2

- It was a windy day || and the child || went out to fly a kite || but she was out of luck that afternoon || as it started to rain || cats and dogs || not too late || after she was beginning to have fun.



- Those who spoke || quickly got an angry response.
- Those who spoke quickly || got an angry response.

- Old men and women.
- Old men || and women.



What marks an intonation?

- Change in pitch.
- Change in fundamental frequency

Fundamental frequency (f_o) of phonation

The number of times the vocal folds vibrate — they are blown apart and come together — per second.

